The visit to the doctor is not in search for an answer, but for validation of a diagnosis that has already taken root in the mind. The physician, in turn, has to attend to two tasks: assess the symptoms before them and treat the health anxiety bred by online self-diagnosis. It is a continuation of an old problem—of patients arriving after a second opinion or alternate medical advice. Online search engines made the task even easier, seek and you had an answer for any of your health queries. Now, AI has accelerated that tendency.

The malaise is serious enough to warrant research on the subject. A 2024 review in the *Indian Journal of Psychiatry* cited a study of the IT sector in Chennai in which 55.6 per cent of the employees showed signs of cyberchondria. A 2026 scoping review in *The Scientific World Journal (TSWJ)*, which analysed international studies, including Indian data, found reported prevalence estimates ranging from 30.7 per cent to 55.6 per cent, with Indian occupational samples among the highest. Another 2022 Indian adult-population study in the *Archives of Mental Health* journal found 45.3 per cent prevalence. Among students, a 2023 study in the *BLDE University Journal of Health Sciences* reported that 22.5 per cent of the cohort was already affected and 36.2 per cent at risk.



AGE OF THE INSTA DIAGNOSIS

In a country where access to medical specialists remains uneven, AI tools come in handy to diagnose ailments that perhaps aren't. The confidence and speed with which they produce fluent, personalised explanations makes them sound authoritative. Generative AI chatbots are even more persuasive, changing how misinformation is created and consumed, says Sudipta Sengupta, founder of The Healthy Indian Project, a fact-checking company. As a result, say doctors, patients imagine even mild symptoms as worst-case scenarios. "Thanks to AI symptom checkers and easy access to health videos online," says Dr Rahul Mehrotra, chief of NIC and clinical cardiology at Artemis Gurgaon, "a lot of people now think that the mildest chest pain means they are having a heart attack. It is thus becoming increasingly common for patients to come to the emergency room in a state of panic and fearing the worst."

The effects show up in different ways. Some panic, seek repeated consultations or ask for scans they may not need, eroding the doctor–patient trust. Others self-medicate, misuse supplements or antibiotics and delay diagnosis. The phenomenon is now so established that researchers have formal screening tools for it, the Cyberchondria Severity Scale (CSS-12) being one of them. In a 2025 validation study in the *Indian Journal of Psychiatry*, researchers from the University of Calcutta and partner institutions formally tested the scale for local populations, underscoring how clinically relevant the condition has become.



"Headaches, dizziness or brief memory lapses, once seen as minor or transient, are now deemed precursors of a stroke or brain tumour thanks to AI"

DR RISHI SHARMA
Consultant-Paediatric Neurologist, Rainbow Hospital

THE EPIDEMIC OF ANXIETY

On a weekday morning, the OPD waiting hall of Max Super Speciality Hospital Saket is milling with patients who seem certain of the disease they are suffering from. A middle-aged man is telling a relative that he has a thyroid condition. A young woman scrolling through her phone mentions PCOS,